

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Nuclear detonation

CHEMICAL RADIATION / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

After a nuclear detonation, get inside the nearest sturdy building as quickly as you can. Move to a basement or central interior area, away from walls, windows, and the roof. Stay inside and tune to official updates; the first 24 hours are especially important unless the building is unsafe or authorities direct you elsewhere.

Do now.

- ☐ **Get inside**
01 Do not remain outdoors looking at the blast or travel across town for a preferred shelter. A substantial building offers better protection than a vehicle or open space.
- ☐ **Go deeper inside**
02 Use a basement or the middle of the building with as much material between you and outdoors as possible. Close doors and windows.
- ☐ **If exposed outdoors, clean up**
03 Once sheltered, remove the outer layer of clothing and set it aside away from people; wash exposed skin with water and soap when available. This reduces contamination brought indoors.
- ☐ **Stay tuned**
04 Use radio, phone, or other available channels for location-specific instructions. Avoid going out to collect family members who are already sheltered elsewhere.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Do not leave protective shelter simply because broadcasts fail. Use an intact basement or central space, keep contaminated outer clothing away from people and use covered water and food. Fire, collapse or another immediate life threat can force a move; a timer alone cannot establish safe outdoor conditions.

Watch for.

Fallout conditions vary by place and time. Do not treat a fixed distance or a clock as an all-clear; use the official instructions for your location. Potassium iodide is not a general radiation antidote and should be taken only when public-health officials advise it.

People & practical needs.

Keep the family together in the correct shelter for the hazard and separate potentially contaminated items from the living area. Use covered food and safe water. Prepare a bag for relocation, but do not send someone outside for it during an active release. For this situation, brief every person on the first action: get inside. Agree who will manage children, pets or mobility needs while that action happens. Fallout conditions vary by place and time. Do not treat a fixed distance or a clock as an all-clear; use the official instructions for your location. Potassium iodide is not a general radiation antidote and should be taken only when public-health officials advise it.

Keep essentials within reach.

For nuclear detonation, prioritize only items needed for the first action and the fallback: Do not leave protective shelter simply because broadcasts fail. Use an intact basement or central space, keep contaminated outer clothing away from people and use covered water and food. Fire, collapse or another immediate life threat can force a move; a timer alone cannot establish safe outdoor conditions. Keep the relevant checklist and contact information within reach. Equipment retrieval must not delay the protective step.

Next decisions.

Arrange water, medications, and a way to receive alerts within the shelter. Leave only for an immediate threat such as fire, collapse, or other life-threatening condition, or when officials direct a safe move.

First decision: Get inside

Do not remain outdoors looking at the blast or travel across town for a preferred shelter. A substantial building offers better protection than a vehicle or open space. Decide which person can carry this out immediately and what would prevent it in your current location. Do not delay the protective step to complete a household worksheet.

When the original plan fails

Do not leave protective shelter simply because broadcasts fail. Use an intact basement or central space, keep contaminated outer clothing away from people and use covered water and food. Fire, collapse or another immediate life threat can force a move; a timer alone cannot establish safe outdoor conditions. Reassess the next available location or resource using the warning signs in this guide; do not assume a promised service is operating.

Before changing location

Fallout conditions vary by place and time. Do not treat a fixed distance or a clock as an all-clear; use the official instructions for your location. Potassium iodide is not a general radiation antidote and should be taken only when public-health officials advise it. Check the actual route and the needs of the person who will have the most difficulty moving. A destination is not confirmed until access and conditions have been checked.

Questions in the field.

What matters before collecting supplies?

After a nuclear detonation, get inside the nearest sturdy building as quickly as you can. Move to a basement or central interior area, away from walls, windows, and the roof. Stay inside and tune to official updates; the first 24 hours are especially important unless the building is unsafe or authorities direct you elsewhere. Collect items only if doing so does not delay this action.

What should another household member do?

Use a second person to handle communication or dependents while the first carries out the immediate action. For nuclear detonation, keep the specific hazard in view: Fallout conditions vary by place and time. Do not treat a fixed distance or a clock as an all-clear; use the official instructions for your location. Potassium iodide is not a general radiation antidote and should be taken only when public-health officials advise it.

What should be written down?

Record when the situation changed, what action was taken and what remains uncertain. For this situation, start with: Stay tuned. Use radio, phone, or other available channels for location-specific instructions. Avoid going out to collect family members who are already sheltered elsewhere. Keep personal notes private; they are not submitted to Osprey Zero.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

CDC · Radiation emergencies

<https://www.cdc.gov/radiation-emergencies/index.html>

CDC · Get inside

<https://www.cdc.gov/radiation-emergencies/response/get-inside.html>

CDC · Stay inside

<https://www.cdc.gov/radiation-emergencies/response/stay-inside.html>

EPA · Radiation emergency preparedness

<https://www.epa.gov/radtown/radiation-emergencies-and-preparedness>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/nuclear-detonation/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.